

Systemization

Omar

2025-12-19

Rationality Freiburg

Why Systemize?

- Pay cost up front → save repeated future costs
- Lock in best version of a process
- Frees attention for important work
- Forces examination of goals

When NOT to Systemize

- Activities you enjoy exploring (e.g., cooking)
- Infrequent tasks
- Low-cost activities
- Things small enough to not matter

Where to Look for Opportunities

Common routines

- Morning: alarm, shower, getting dressed
- Meals: planning, shopping, cleanup
- Work: commute, repetitive tasks
- Computer: startup, tab management
- Social: connecting, planning, messaging

Familiar Spaces

- Bedroom: laundry, clutter, lighting
- Bathroom: supplies, organization
- Kitchen: dishes, storage, supplies
- Living room: furniture, entertainment
- Vehicle: storage, clutter
- Workspace: desk, chair, equipment
- Bag: weight, organization

Shoulds and Obligations

- Physical health: eating, exercise, rest
- Financial: banking, budgeting
- Intellectual: reading, learning
- Relationships: family, friends, colleagues
- Career: work/life balance, projects
- Emotional: hobbies, sleep, support
- Community: volunteering, obligations

The Key Question

“How can I make this take as little attention as possible?”

- Not “how to do everything”
- Focus on **freeing attention**
- Let systems be your personal assistant
- Make problems take care of themselves

Multiple Systems vs. One Master System

- Usually better: multiple small systems
 - Shopping list
 - Kitchen cleaning algorithm
 - Email workflow
- Few people: one master system
- Choose what minimizes **attentional overhead**

Qualities of Good Systems

Effortless

- Avoid ongoing willpower or continuous decisions
- Single burst of effort → long-term savings
- Example: Stock kitchen with good food, remove bad food

Reliable

- Foolproof reminders and objective checks
- Let your mind actually let go
- Example: Location-based phone reminders

Invisible

- Reduce clutter and noise
- Example: Hidden calendar with text reminders

Algorithm (min effort version)

- Choose an aspect of your life to systemize (1 min)
- Identify the specific snags or attention-sucks (5 min)
- **Directly implement** (or think of) targeted interventions to address each one (5 min)

Examples

- Optimize Darktable photo editing workflow and documentation
- Optimize my desk and locker at work to remove friction and make it nice
- Optimize my gym bag to remove things I don't need. Create a clearer check list for things to take to the gym.
- Relabel and sort home document folders

Source

Systemization

Duncan Sabien / CFAR

<https://www.lesswrong.com/posts/QKpmPBpyCdNbBKAdR/systemization>